# we built this town on shaky ground

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# we built this town on shaky ground

by driluth


## Summary

It’s been a week since Adora last saw the sun, and even longer since she last saw Catra.

—

A Catradoa Post Apoc AU.


## Notes

See the end of the work for notes

"Let's be the same wound if we must bleed. / Let's fight side by side, even if the enemy / is ourselves: I am yours, you are mine."

— Tommy Olofsson

It's been a week since Adora last saw the sun, and even longer since she last saw Catra. Shadow Weaver is to blame for both. It was Shadow Weaver's idea to move into the basement of the hospital they've found sanctuary in. But some childish part of Adora wants to blame Shadow Weaver for whatever has been wrong with the weather lately; it storms regularly, or is still dark out when it should be day. Or there's lightning and thunder with no rain. But it was Shadow Weaver who sent out Catra, Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio on a supply run two weeks ago. Two weeks. It's the longest anyone has been on a supply run before coming back.

Most don't come back.

Or if they do come back… they're not themselves, anymore.

Adora had insisted on going. This is the first mission Catra's been on without her since they were thirteen. They work better together, and Shadow Weaver *knows* that. But Shadow Weaver wouldn't let her, said that Adora was more needed in the Fright Zone. It's as if she knew the weather would get bad. The hospital has always been creepy, but it's all Adora knows since the retirement home she was raised in got overrun. At least as a taller building the hospital gets more light—the basement is miserable. And Adora doesn't understand why she's been ordered to stay down here with the other three remaining force captains. Shadow Weaver says it's due to the weather, but Adora suspects it's more than that.

*

It’s only the next day (or night, Adora’s lost track of time) that Shadow Weaver lets them return to the hospital with everyone else. It’s still dark outside. But it seems like it has finally stopped storming. Shadow Weaver requested everyone meet in the cafeteria in the next hour to discuss strategy, for what, Adora isn’t sure, but she figures a nap couldn’t hurt in the meantime. She heads towards the wing where she and Catra share a room.

Where Catra is standing, holding a duffel bag.

“Catra! What are you doing here?”

Catra tosses the duffel bag her way. It’s only then that Adora realizes it’s hers. “There’s no time to get into it, Adora. We have to leave.”

Adora can’t fathom it. She’s been to other places on her supply runs, but nowhere else had the same security as the hospital, even within the Fright Zone. “I'm sorry, did I miss something? Is that what Shadow Weaver's meeting is about?"

Catra's eyes narrow. “We’re not going to the meeting, Adora. We’re leaving, and we need to leave now.”

Adora takes Catra in. She's not joking about ditching, she means it. “I don’t understand.”

“I’m the only one who made it back.”

Adora forgets to breathe, for a moment. It's always a risk, these missions, which is why force captains are usually involved. The ones with most experience can look after their team. But even though Catra isn't a force captain yet, she has just as much experience as Adora, she knows what she's doing. Adora can see it in Catra's eyes, she's not just scared, she's scarred by whatever it was she saw out there.

“Everyone else on my team… they turned. Thaymor was completely overrun by a horde that somehow wasn’t mentioned in the report. There were way too many for it to have been overlooked. Adora, I’m convinced Shadow Weaver sent us there to die. I’m lucky I made it back.”

“She wouldn’t do that,” Adora insists, but as the words leave her mouth, it feels like a lie, like she's convincing herself. "She knows we actually need the supplies, she wouldn't risk four lives."

“Then tell me, Adora. Why do you think she sent me out there and not you?”

Adora doesn’t have an answer for her. It’s not that simple. It’s been decades since the world fell, and there were more dead than living walking. There was strength in numbers, in their community. But if there were a few less mouths to feed… If the reports intentionally left out a growing horde... “Where would we go?” she ends up asking.

“It doesn't matter. As long as we’re together, we can handle it.”

“Catra, we need a plan. We can’t just get up and leave. Especially if there's more dead out there and we can't count on going to Thaymor.”

“How long do you think it’ll be before we get overrun? Think about it, each mission we’ve been on lately has been closer and closer. The Fright Zone isn’t going to last forever, and I’m not going to be here when it falls.”

Adora wants to go with her, she does. If the rest of their friends are dead and it's Shadow Weaver's fault, Adora doesn't have a choice. She'll follow Catra anywhere, within reason. But Adora notices the way Catra's tapping her foot, the fear that hasn't left her eyes. “What is it you’re not telling me?” Catra looks startled by the question, as if Adora hasn’t known her their whole lives, as if she doesn't know her tells, her bluffs. “If what you’re telling me is true, Catra, I’ll go with you. But you have to tell me everything.”

“Adora, there’s no time.” The words come out strained.

“Then make time,” she urges.

Catra glares at her. Adora braces herself for another argument. But Catra doesn’t say another word. What Catra does is worse.

Catra rolls up her sleeve, revealing a wound. A bite mark, to be exact, above Catra’s wrist.

Adora knows the rules. It’s how she’s survived this long. Unless there’s the means to saw off a limb quickly, going for the head is what it will take. The brain. Adora’s seen the dead crawl with missing limbs, Adora’s seen a severed head still move its mouth, trying to bite. It needs to be done quickly, or the bitten will suffer. Delirium, fever, the bite burning. There is no cure. There is no way to prevent turning once it spreads.

Adora’s sword is with her. It’s always with her. Guns draw attention, and are best at a distance. A sword doesn’t run out of bullets.

But this is Catra.

“Do you understand now?” Catra asks. She doesn’t look at the sword. She maintains eye contact.

Adora’s the one who breaks it. The bite mark isn’t bleeding. It looks—it looks as though it’s healing. “When did you get bit?” she asks, voice low.

“The first night. I promise. That’s when we got swarmed. Completely surrounded. I have another one near my ankle, but that one looks a little worse.” Catra steps towards her, Adora doesn’t back away. “I thought I’d never see you again. I stayed out in the Whispering Woods waiting to die. I didn’t.”

“You didn’t die,” Adora repeats.

Catra shrugs. “Shadow Weaver always said there was something wrong with me.”

“If Shadow Weaver found out you’re immune—”

“We don’t know what this is, and I don’t want Shadow Weaver to find out. She already assumed I died. Let’s keep it that way. Will you go with me?”

Adora takes Catra’s hand, and they stand there like that, for a moment. She won’t let Catra go back out there alone. “I’ll go with you.”

*

They make it out of the Fright Zone without being spotted. There’s more dead than usual, and when they make it to the Whispering Woods, Adora’s heart sinks. There’s more dead in one place than she’s ever seen.

“Which direction?”

Catra squeezes her hand tight. “This way.”

Adora follows.

They still when a Fright Zone alarm goes off in the distance. Adora doesn’t think it’s from the hospital, but the dead shift, and head that way instead.

The two of them stay tight, stay close, not wanting to get caught off guard by one that strays.

Somehow, they make it through the night. It’s overcast in the morning.

They agree that they should rest. It’s the first thing they agree on. They find shelter in a building that seems sound. They take turns keeping watch that day. And the night.

And then they move on. It’s still dark the next morning. Catra's leading them towards Bright Moon, Adora reckons. There’s been rumors about a community there, a place that offers more than shelter, a place that’s still like *before*. Shadow Weaver said it was a cruel thing to offer false hope in the world they live in. But now Adora wonders if Shadow Weaver prefers it.

*

They end up taking a wrong turn, somewhere. They’re out of their depths, further away from the Fright Zone than they’ve ever been.

Back to back, Catra with a gun in one hand and a dagger in the other, Adora with her sword in both.

It’s instinct, driving the sword into skulls. It’s instinct, scanning their surroundings for a gap, a chance to run. Catra only has so many bullets. Adora only has so much time before the next one approaches.

And it’s instinct, when she notices one with its eyes on Catra, getting close. Catra has her knife in the skull of one, and uses her gun to hit another one in the head. So she stabs it for Catra before it can get any closer. Then there’s a scream, from someone, and a sudden pain in her shoulder. Adora winces as she removes her sword. Before she can get a better look at the one with blood in its mouth, Catra stabs it with her dagger. She leaves her dagger in its skull.

“Catra?”

“Adora,” Catra says. And it doesn’t matter that there’s more of them, in the distance. What matters is the frightened way Catra’s looking at her.

Adora presses her fingers against the bite, as if it could do anything.

“Come on,” Catra says. “We’re going to run for it.”

They come across what might have been a tree house, once. It's not very tall, but it will offer enough privacy until the rest of the dead walk past it. It offers enough privacy for Adora to—no, she can't think it. Not yet. It starts with a fever. She still has time.

They stay quiet as the dead pass beneath them.

“What are the chances we’re both immune, huh?” Adora asks once it’s safe. Not that it’s really safe.

Adora waits for Catra to call her an idiot.

She doesn’t.

“Why did you do that?” Catra asks instead.

“I didn’t think.”

“It’d be fine if it bit me,” Catra says, louder. “You should have let it bite me.”

“It still could have killed you. And you left your dagger behind.”

“It doesn’t matter.”

“It doesn’t matter?”

“If you turn, if you die, I won’t need it. I’m not leaving you.”

It’s only then that Adora realizes that she’s crying. They both are.

Catra moves closer to her, letting Adora rest her shoulder on her head. The bite mark is tender. And it itches. “I’m sorry,” Adora thinks she says. She’s starting to feel light headed. She wants to blame the loss of blood. But then, there’s something warm, something that feels good. She tries to say something else.

“What is it?” Catra asks.

“It’s getting lighter,” she’s able to manage. "The sun’s finally coming out.”

“Come on,” Catra says, standing up, offering her hand to Adora. “Let’s get you a better view.”

End Notes

I wanted to leave it slightly open ended... let's just say I can imagine a universe where it's nothing but tragic as well as one where somehow they're both immune. (I mean, statistically...) That is up for you to decide.

Title comes from Seafret's "Atlantis." Totally not inspired by The Walking Dead or a video game/tv show with characters whose names rhyme with Kelly and Miley who broke my heart eleven years ago. Definitely not. And maybe a little nod to Percabeth when Annabeth protects Percy even when (to her knowledge) he didn't need it. As a treat. Last time Adora saw the sun is a reference to Sinners too bc I am obsessed with that movie and how could I not be! Lightning and thunder with no rain--Planet of the Apes. Because why not.

I know angst is not new for me but angst without (potentially) a happy ending, not so much. Sorry friends, I wanted to experiment with something short and not so sweet, so here we are.

The good news is, I do have a longer (and sweeter) fit update next week, for fans of a messy ex girlfriends YouTube AU. Stay tuned.

Wishing everyone a Happy Halloween!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!